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From the editor-in-chief

Indians, as we all know, tend to be somewhat obsessed with their past. There is, however, a very thin line between taking pride in a country's history and being stuck in a state of permanent nostalgia. The greatest gifts of history are the lessons we are able to take away from it.

Since the turn of the millennium, there has been a distinct shift in India's mood. Perhaps that is because India is a young country with half its people under 25. It may also have to do with our recent prosperity and growing confidence of where we stand in the world. As we approach another Independence Day and acknowledge where modern India came from, I believe this is the time not for yesterdays, but for tomorrow.

We are living through one of the most dramatic and transformational events in human history. India Shining made for a disastrous political slogan, but all around us, there is incontrovertible proof that India is rising. With the world's fifth-largest economy, an expanding market, a young workforce and one of the most astute electorates in the world, India is at a tipping point from where it can fast-track its development and take its place amongst the leading powers of the world.

It is also confronted by enormous challenges, some ironically similar to those that confronted our founding fathers in 1947: raising a vast population out of poverty, ensuring that people of different faiths and communities could co-exist, creating infrastructure with an eye on the future and ensuring sustainable economic growth.

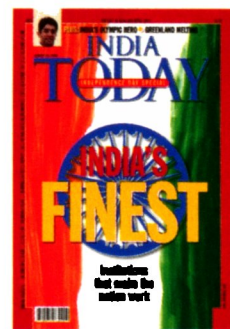
To mark India's 62nd Independence Day, we asked some of the finest minds to imagine their India of the future, where it will be a decade or so down the line in politics, business, culture, health and sports. So in this special I-Day issue we have provocative essays from reputed scholars and historians, politicians and businessmen and on the topics that will shape India Tomorrow: democracy and justice, challenges of leadership, the politics of religion, the politics of poverty as well as the poverty of politics, how to become a superpower in economy and geopolitics, how to become a sporting giant, the digital possibilities and technological opportunities.

The ideas contained in this special issue give us hope as well as anxiety. They lead us to the many potentials and possibilities of 21st century India. They also remind us what went wrong, what to avoid in the future and tell us what should be done.

As Nobel Laureate Amartya Sen says, "India Tomorrow will not come about with just one magic bullet." What you will find inside this issue is a profusion of magic bullets to spur us to a brighter future.

This week's special Independence Day issue is put together by Editor-at-Large S. Prasannarajan, who says, "It's wonderful to believe that the Indian awakening is the next big global bang, but our aspiration is not yet matched by the actions of our political class." The ideas it contains challenge us, inspire us, stimulate us and even show the way. Hopefully, they will make us wiser too.

(Aroon Purie)



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